

A New Challenge, A Familiar Guide

Vocabulary, Grammar, Comprehension & Conversation Handout
Intermediate Level

THE TEXT

A New Challenge, A Familiar Guide

After submitting my manuscript to my first target journal, I finally allowed myself a short breath of relief — but only a short one. As a research pharmacist, I knew the next task was already waiting: applying for an internal grant with an entirely new proposal. For me, every finished project is less of an ending and more of a stepping stone toward the next question worth asking.

True to my challenge-seeking nature, I did not want this new proposal to be a simple extension of what I had already done. Instead, I wanted to push the current workflow further — to refine it so that it could answer a research question more comprehensively, and, more importantly, address a clinical problem with greater meaning for patients. That ambition was exactly where I began drafting.

The aim was intriguing, but so was the challenge that came with it. The more I read and thought, the more I realized how much I still did not know. Where should I begin? Which methods would give me the most reliable answers? How could I build a proposal strong enough to convince the review committee? These questions circled in my mind day and night, and I often found myself staring at a blank document, unsure which sentence to write first.

Then, in the middle of this uncertainty, something unexpected happened. While browsing research articles one evening, I happened to come across a paper written by a former teacher of mine from school. For a moment, I could hardly believe it — the same teacher who had once introduced me to the world of research was now publishing in a field closely related to the very problem I was trying to solve.

I brought the discovery to my supervisor the next morning, and with his permission, I reached out to her right away. To my delight, she replied warmly and generously agreed to guide me on the path ahead. In that instant, the long road before me no longer felt quite so lonely. What had seemed like an overwhelming challenge suddenly became an exciting journey — one I would not have to walk alone.

Sometimes, I think, the universe has a quiet way of placing the right people in our lives exactly when we need them most.

VOCABULARY

#	Word	Definition & Example from Text
1	submit (v.)	to formally hand in a document or piece of work for review. <i>"After submitting my manuscript to my first target journal..."</i>
2	manuscript (n.)	a written document, especially one prepared for publication. <i>"Submitting my manuscript to my first target journal."</i>
3	relief (n.)	a feeling of comfort when something difficult or worrying ends. <i>"I finally allowed myself a short breath of relief."</i>
4	proposal (n.)	a formal plan or suggestion put forward for consideration. <i>"Applying for an internal grant with an entirely new proposal."</i>
5	grant (n.)	a sum of money given for a specific purpose, often for research or study. <i>"Applying for an internal grant."</i>
6	extension (n.)	the act of making something longer or adding to it. <i>"A simple extension of what I had already done."</i>
7	comprehensively (adv.)	in a complete and thorough way. <i>"Answer a research question more comprehensively."</i>

#	Word	Definition & Example from Text
8	ambition (n.)	a strong desire to achieve something important. <i>"That ambition was exactly where I began drafting."</i>
9	reliable (adj.)	able to be trusted or depended on. <i>"Which methods would give me the most reliable answers?"</i>
10	convince (v.)	to cause someone to believe or agree. <i>"A proposal strong enough to convince the review committee."</i>
11	come across (phrasal v.)	to find or meet by chance. <i>"I happened to come across a paper written by a former teacher."</i>
12	generously (adv.)	in a kind and unselfish way, willing to give time or help. <i>"She generously agreed to guide me on the path ahead."</i>

Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best answer.

1. After working on her thesis for two years, she finally felt a sense of ____ when she handed it in.

- A) ambition
- B) relief
- C) proposal

D) grant

2. The university gave her a ____ of \$10,000 to support her research project.

A) grant

B) manuscript

C) relief

D) extension

3. The writer ____ her manuscript to several publishers, hoping one would accept it.

A) convinced

B) submitted

C) refined

D) addressed

4. A good doctor always gives patients ____ information based on scientific evidence.

A) reliable

B) generous

C) intriguing

D) comprehensive

5. Please read through my ____ and let me know if any parts are unclear before I send it to the journal.

A) grant

B) extension

- C) manuscript
- D) ambition

6. I was walking through the library when I ____ an old photograph hidden between the pages of a book.

- A) came across
- B) submitted
- C) addressed
- D) refined

7. His ____ to become a doctor kept him studying late into the night for many years.

- A) relief
- B) extension
- C) ambition
- D) grant

8. The teacher ____ shared her notes with all the students before the final exam.

- A) reliably
- B) comprehensively
- C) generously
- D) surely

9. The lawyer tried to ____ the jury that his client was innocent.

- A) submit

- B) convince
- C) refine
- D) address

10. The report covers the topic ____, including every detail from start to finish.

- A) comprehensively
- B) generously
- C) roughly
- D) briefly

11. He asked for an ____ of the deadline because he needed more time to finish his work.

- A) ambition
- B) proposal
- C) extension
- D) relief

12. Before presenting the plan to the board, she wrote a detailed ____ explaining every step.

- A) proposal
- B) grant
- C) relief
- D) manuscript

Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

Use the correct form of the word from the box to complete each sentence.

**submit | manuscript | relief | proposal | grant | extension | comprehensively
| ambition | reliable | convince | come across | generously**

1. She felt great _____ when she heard that her application had been approved.
2. The scientist _____ her research paper to the journal last week.
3. He has the _____ to become the youngest manager in the company.
4. While cleaning the attic, I _____ a box of my grandfather's old letters.
5. Our team wrote a detailed _____ to secure funding for the new project.
6. The government offered a research _____ to support the new medical study.
7. This book explains the history of medicine _____, covering many centuries.
8. She _____ donated her old books to the school library.
9. Please revise your _____ before we submit it to the publisher.

10. This watch has been _____ for over twenty years; it has never broken down.

11. It took me an hour to _____ my sister to come to the party with me.

12. The teacher gave us a two-day _____ because the project was more difficult than expected.

GRAMMAR

Pattern 1: “After + V-ing, S + V...”

Form: After + gerund phrase, subject + verb

Use: To describe two actions in sequence — the second one happens after the first.

Example from text: *“After submitting my manuscript to my first target journal, I finally allowed myself a short breath of relief.”*

More examples:

- After finishing her homework, she went out to play with her friends.
- After arriving in the city, we checked into our hotel immediately.
- After reading the book, he felt inspired to write his own story.

Pattern 2: “So + be/aux + subject” (inversion for echoing a quality)

Form: So + be/auxiliary verb + subject (used to say the same quality applies to the second thing)

Use: To emphasize that something shares the same quality just mentioned.

Example from text: *“The aim was intriguing, but so was the challenge that came with it.”*

More examples:

- The food at the restaurant was amazing, and so was the service.
- The mountain was steep, but so was our determination to reach the top.
- My sister loves painting, and so do I.

Pattern 3: “What had seemed... suddenly became...”

Form: What + had + past participle + like/adjective, (suddenly/now) + became + noun/adjective

Use: To express a dramatic change in how something is perceived — from one state to a very different one.

Example from text: *“What had seemed like an overwhelming challenge suddenly became an exciting journey.”*

More examples:

- What had seemed like a boring subject suddenly became my favorite class.
- What had seemed impossible at first gradually became a daily habit.
- What had seemed like a small mistake suddenly became a serious problem.

Pattern 4: “To + one’s + noun (of emotion), S + V...”

Form: To + my/his/her + noun expressing feeling (delight, surprise, relief, etc.), subject + verb

Use: To show a person’s emotional reaction to something that happened.

Example from text: *“To my delight, she replied warmly and generously agreed to guide me on the path ahead.”*

More examples:

- To my surprise, the test was much easier than I had expected.
- To her relief, the lost wallet was returned by a kind stranger.
- To our disappointment, the concert was cancelled at the last minute.

Practice 3: Multiple Choice (Grammar)

Choose the best answer.

1. _____ the movie, we went out for dinner.
A) After watching
B) After watched
C) After we watching
D) After to watch

2. The weather was cold, and _____ the wind.
A) so did
B) so was
C) so were
D) so has

3. _____ my shock, my name was called first on the list.
A) For
B) In
C) To
D) With

4. What had seemed like a simple question _____ a complicated debate.
A) suddenly became
B) suddenly become

- C) suddenly becoming
- D) suddenly becomes

5. _____ home, he took off his shoes and lay on the sofa.

- A) After arriving
- B) After arrive
- C) After he arriving
- D) After to arrive

6. The journey was exhausting, but _____ rewarding.

- A) so was it
- B) so it was
- C) so was
- D) so it is

7. _____ our amazement, the little girl played the piano beautifully.

- A) At
- B) To
- C) By
- D) On

8. _____ like a tiny seed quickly became a tall tree.

- A) What had seemed
- B) What seems

C) What have seemed

D) What seeming

9. _____ dinner, the children helped wash the dishes.

A) After had

B) After having

C) After to have

D) After has

10. The students were excited about the trip, and _____ the teachers.

A) so did

B) so were

C) so are

D) so was

11. To Maria's _____, her brother forgot her birthday again.

A) delight

B) joy

C) disappointment

D) relief

12. _____ like a cold and distant stranger gradually became my closest friend.

A) What had seemed

B) What seems

C) What is seeming

D) What seem

Practice 4: Sentence Transformation

Rewrite each sentence using the pattern in brackets. Keep the original meaning.

1. He finished his homework. Then he watched television. (After + V-ing)

2. The road was long. The scenery was also beautiful. (so + be/aux + subject)

3. The task looked impossible, but it turned into a rewarding project. (What had seemed... became...)

4. I was very surprised when I saw my old classmate at the airport. (To my surprise, ...)

5. She took a deep breath. Then she began her speech. (After + V-ing)

6. The coffee was delicious, and the dessert was too. (so + be/aux + subject)

7. At first, the book seemed boring, but it later turned into my favorite novel. (What had seemed... became...)

8. We felt great relief when we heard that the test was postponed. (To our relief, ...)

COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS

A. Literal Understanding

1. What did the writer do with her manuscript before turning to her next task?

2. What is the writer preparing to apply for after submitting her manuscript?

B. Inference

3. Why do you think the writer describes every finished project as “a stepping stone toward the next question”?

4. What does the writer mean when she says the road “no longer felt quite so lonely”?

C. Critical Thinking

5. The writer says, “The more I read and thought, the more I realized how much I still did not know.” Do you think this is a helpful feeling for a researcher, or a discouraging one? Why?

6. How does meeting her former teacher change the writer's view of the challenge ahead? What does this suggest about how we handle difficult tasks?

D. Personal Response

7. The writer believes "the universe has a quiet way of placing the right people in our lives exactly when we need them most." Do you agree with this idea? Why or why not?

8. Have you ever felt stuck on a difficult task, just like the writer staring at a blank document? How did you move forward?

CONVERSATION QUESTIONS

Theme: Facing challenges and the people who guide us.

1. When you face a big new challenge, what is usually your first reaction — excitement, worry, or something else?
2. Do you enjoy tasks that push you beyond what you already know, or do you prefer tasks you feel confident about? Why?
3. Has a teacher, mentor, or family member ever appeared in your life at just the right moment? What happened?
4. If you could meet a former teacher today, what would you most want to ask or tell them?
5. How do you usually get started when you feel completely unsure where to begin?
6. Do you think asking for guidance is a sign of strength or weakness? Why?
7. In the future, would you rather guide others through a challenge, or receive guidance yourself? Why?

ANSWER KEY

Practice 1: Vocabulary Multiple Choice

1. B
2. A
3. B
4. A
5. C
6. A
7. C
8. C
9. B
10. A
11. C
12. A

Practice 2: Vocabulary Fill in the Blanks

1. relief
2. submitted
3. ambition
4. came across
5. proposal
6. grant
7. comprehensively
8. generously
9. manuscript

- 10. reliable
- 11. convince
- 12. extension

Practice 3: Grammar Multiple Choice

- 1. A
- 2. B
- 3. C
- 4. A
- 5. A
- 6. C
- 7. B
- 8. A
- 9. B
- 10. B
- 11. C
- 12. A

Practice 4: Sentence Transformation (Sample Answers)

- 1. After finishing his homework, he watched television.
- 2. The road was long, and so was the scenery beautiful. (Also acceptable: The road was long, and so beautiful was the scenery.)
- 3. What had seemed like an impossible task became a rewarding project.
- 4. To my surprise, I saw my old classmate at the airport.
- 5. After taking a deep breath, she began her speech.
- 6. The coffee was delicious, and so was the dessert.

7. What had seemed like a boring book became my favorite novel.
8. To our relief, we heard that the test was postponed.

Comprehension (Sample Answers)

1. She submitted her manuscript to her first target journal.
2. She is preparing to apply for an internal grant with a new proposal.
3. Because she sees every finished project as the beginning of a new question, not the end. It shows her attitude of continuous learning and curiosity.
4. She means that after her former teacher agreed to guide her, she no longer felt alone in facing the challenge; having support made the journey feel easier.
5. (Answers will vary.) It can be helpful because it shows humility and keeps the researcher learning. It can also feel discouraging at times, but it usually leads to growth.
6. Meeting her former teacher turns the challenge from something scary into something exciting. It shows that having the right guidance can change how we see a difficult task.
7. (Answers will vary.)
8. (Answers will vary.)